



CONCORDE'S LAST FLIGHT

The last commercial Concorde flight took place on October 24, 2003. Supersonic passenger flight had proved a technological success story but a commercial failure, suggesting that the future of aviation did not necessarily lie in ever increasing speed or range.

transformation. Alongside constant experimentation with fresh approaches to the technological and commercial aspects of aviation there was an inherent conservatism that had its own rationale. Both civil and military aviation were

mature businesses that at times saw little logic in exposing themselves to the expense and risk of major innovation.

Supersonic passenger transports had once seemed the way of the future. It appeared obvious that air travel would simply become faster. But as the sorry commercial history of Concorde and its even less successful supersonic rivals showed, the price for speed could become greater than people were prepared to pay – whether in terms of the cost of a seat or noise pollution and other environmental damage. Before its withdrawal from service in 2003, Concorde had found a market niche, but it was a small and relatively insignificant one that no new airliner was rushing to fill.

The fate of the Boeing Sonic Cruiser was another case in point. This revolutionary airliner was presented as the future of passenger aviation in March 2001. It was intended to carry up to 300 passengers at a cruising speed of Mach 0.98 – just below the speed of sound, thus avoiding the “sonic boom.” But negative reaction from world airlines soon forced Boeing to abandon their new fast

Continuing innovation

If you were writing a general account of life in the 20th century, aircraft would only figure marginally for the first three decades. Some reputable single-volume histories of World War I barely mention aviation at all. Until the late 1930s, aircraft were a craze that generated heroes, but really had little effect on the lives of any but a small minority of people. It was World War II that truly brought aircraft center stage, transforming the practice of warfare. Commercial aviation took until the jet age to begin to effect a dramatic change in leisure and business. Even in the United States, in the early 1960s half the population had still never flown. But by the 1990s over a billion passengers were flying worldwide every year.

It was an open question at the start of the third millennium whether flight still had revolutionary possibilities, or whether it had become, like tanks in warfare or railroads in passenger transportation, an established feature of the landscape that would endure (with improvements) but undergo no further dramatic expansion or

aircraft. Airline bosses were far more eager on cutting costs than they were on increasing speed. More seats, lower maintenance costs, and reduced fuel consumption were the kind of unglamorous achievements that would really sell an aircraft.

The most obvious scope for future of supersonic aircraft lay in business jets, such as the Aerion Corporation's AS2, intended to provide luxury transport for the world's wealthy elite. Another possible pointer to the future was NASA's interest in Quiet Supersonic Technology, designed to combine supersonic speed with low noise and high fuel economy. But no one expected to see an airliner carrying, for example, 300 passengers at twice the speed of sound, even though this was perfectly feasible in terms of technology.

Money matters

In military aviation, the quest for ever-improved performance came up against cost-conscious politicians who were increasingly inclined to query the need for ever-more-expensive aircraft. These could easily seem like toys for the boys to play with. In the United States, the technological lead over any currently conceivable enemies was the most potent deterrent to investment in expensive high-tech military aviation. It did not pass unnoticed that a successful air attack on America was achieved by a bunch of young Muslims whose technology was limited to knives, box-cutters, and the ability to pilot aircraft.

The controversy that surrounded the Lockheed Martin F-22 Raptor, the sophisticated American fighter that came into service in December 2005, turned precisely on such questions of cost and function. The F-22 was designed as a replacement for the F-15, to guarantee the United States air superiority against any other fighter force. It marked a clear advance over its predecessors

WHITE WHALE

The Airbus Beluga is one of the world's largest transport aircraft by volume. It is basically the bottom half of an A300 widebody airliner with a bulbous cargo hold mounted on top. The Beluga was designed to carry sections of Airbus airliners between factories in different countries.

